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What separates you from those who need your help? Just a keyboard, the will to serve, and a bridging organisation

Prakash Ballakoor

You know all too well your help is needed, and that's true in any country, any time. You can help by recycling stuff. You can help by approaching governments and supporting social causes. You can help by directly feeding the poor. This is all confused, but the idea is: Your Help Is Needed. But let this not be a sob story, and let's get to our point.

Various hindrances prevent you from contributing towards causes. Helping with child welfare means working with NGOs after having understood the problems. Educating weaker sections of society means volunteering as a teacher, possibly in a language you don't (yet) know. And so forth... and in today's busy life, there are time constraints. Yes, you can take time out, but what can possibly stop you from crashing in front of the telly at the end of a hard day? In addition, this is India, and volunteering organisations—assuming you can't help directly—may be located far away or even in other countries. So here's the broad picture: you want to help. You have the time, strictly speaking. You have the skills. NGOs and other helping bodies exist. So what's to be done?

Yes, The Internet!

It turns out you can now volunteer over the Internet—and so, much to your initial dismay, you have no excuse. (But if you have a conscience, you'll be glad.) What you first need is a strong desire to contribute for a cause. You can do your part by taking up tasks that do not require an on-site presence. Various tasks—such as reading out and recording of passages from textbooks for visually impaired students, and documentation of activities and writing